

# The Temporalities of Meaning:, Nominal Fixity, and the Return to Gestural Consensus

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## Overview

This *Pensée* contends that the operational logic of large language models (LLMs) exposes a fundamental tension between two historical modes of linguistic meaning: the nominal, taxonomical stabilisation characteristic of early modern English (circa 17th century) and the dynamic, relation-driven ontology that precedes and underlies all formal language systems. While human prompt-engineering often employs reductive, noun-heavy constructions to constrain LLM output, the interpretive validation of that output relies upon a pre-linguistic, consensual faculty rooted in gesture and shared attention. Rather than constituting a return to 17th-century linguistic structures, the human–LLM interface produces a bifurcation of temporal registers, revealing that the early modern fixation on nominal essence was an historical detour from the more fundamental, context-dependent nature of meaning.

## Introduction

The advent of transformer-based language models has reintroduced a philosophical question that had lain dormant beneath centuries of grammatical codification: namely, whether meaning inheres in static lexical entities or emerges from relational configurations within a communicative field. It has been proposed that contemporary interactions with LLMs are precipitating a return to the linguistic character of the early 17th century, a period marked by the systematic stabilisation of English into a noun-oriented, taxonomic instrument suited to legal, theological, and empirical classification. While this observation captures an important shift in pragmatic usage, a closer examination suggests that the dynamic, probabilistic mechanics of LLMs do not merely resurrect early modern nominalism; rather, they compel a re-engagement with an older, performative stratum of language grounded in gestural indexicality and intersubjective consensus.

## The Nominal Stabilisation of Early Modern English

The early 17th century represents a pivotal moment in the history of the English language. The publication of the King James Bible (1611) and the subsequent lexicographical projects of the century sought to fix orthography, syntax, and semantic scope

with unprecedented rigidity. This endeavour was philosophically underwritten by Ramist logic, which demanded the hierarchical classification of all knowledge into discrete, noun-anchored categories. In this epistemic regime, nouns functioned as the primary carriers of ontological weight; verbs and modifiers were relegated to a subsidiary, descriptive role. Language thus became a technology of possession and delimitation, mirroring the contemporaneous legal and colonial expansions that required unambiguous reference to persons, territories, and commodities. Meaning, under this paradigm, was conceived as a stable cargo transported from speaker to hearer, with the noun acting as the sealed container.

## **Ramist Logic: Foundations and Influence at the Dawn of the 17th Century**

To understand the intellectual climate of early 17th-century England, one must examine the profound influence of Petrus Ramus (1515–1572), the French humanist and educational reformer whose works became central to Protestant pedagogy, particularly at Cambridge University. Ramus's project was, in essence, a radical critique of the entrenched Aristotelian scholasticism that dominated European universities. He sought to create a more accessible and practical system of logic, one that could be taught more efficiently and applied more directly to disciplines beyond philosophy, including law, medicine, and even literature.

### **The Core of Ramist Logic: Dichotomous Division and Method**

The hallmark of Ramist thought was its reliance on dichotomous division as the primary tool for structuring knowledge. This method, which Ramus attributed to Plato, involved breaking down a subject into two mutually exclusive and exhaustive parts, and then subdividing each part in the same manner. For example, in Ramist dialectic, the field of logic was divided into "invention" (the discovery of arguments) and "judgment" (the evaluation of those arguments). "Invention" was then further divided into "artificial" and "inartificial" arguments, and so on. This process could be carried to minute levels of detail, and Ramist textbooks typically featured comprehensive tables that mapped out these dichotomies.

This system had several profound consequences for early modern thought. First, it promoted a view of knowledge as a fixed, hierarchical tree structure that could be exhaustively mapped and understood. This resonated with the encyclopaedic ambitions of the 17th century, influencing figures such as Johann Heinrich Alsted and John Amos Comenius. Second, it prioritised clarity and precision. By reducing complex subjects to binary oppositions, Ramist logic encouraged a form of thinking that sought to define and delimit concepts with stark boundaries. Francis Bacon, though a critic of Ramus's rigid method, was nonetheless influenced by this drive for clarity and is said to have had his thinking markedly affected by the Ramist emphasis on testing and precision. Indeed, some scholars have argued that Bacon's own doctrine of "Forms" gains coherence when read through the lens of Ramus's logic.

## Key Texts and Their Circulation

The foundation of Ramist influence was textual. Ramus’s principal work, the *Dialectica* (also known as the *Dialecticae Institutiones*), was first published in 1543. Its popularity in England is evidenced by the numerous editions and translations that appeared throughout the late 16th and 17th centuries. Library catalogues record English translations of the *Dialectica* printed in London in 1574, 1581, 1626, 1632, 1636, and as late as 1651. These were not merely scholarly texts; they were designed for pedagogical use, often “digested into questions and answers for the more facility of understanding”.

Furthermore, Ramus’s influence was disseminated through the works of his followers. The English Puritan logician Alexander Richardson (c.1565–1613) wrote a popular logic textbook in the Ramist tradition titled *The logicians school-master: or, A comment upon Ramus logick*, first published in 1629. This text not only explicated Ramus’s dialectic but also extended his method to grammar, rhetoric, and other fields. Such works were standard reading in English universities and grammar schools, ensuring that generations of scholars, clergymen, and gentlemen were trained in the Ramist method.

## The Ramist Legacy in English Literature and Thought

The impact of Ramism extended far beyond the university lecture hall. By the early 17th century, Ramist logic had become a foundational component of the intellectual toolkit for many writers and thinkers. John Milton, for instance, was a notable adherent; his own *Artis logicae plenior institutio* (1672) was a version of Ramus’s dialectic. Milton, following Ramus, insisted on the importance of a solid foundation in logical invention before engaging in literary production and criticised the schools of his time for neglecting this basic training.

The influence can also be traced in popular literature. Scholars have demonstrated that Ramist dialectic and method shaped the logic, structure, and themes of 17th-century English prose pamphlets, such as those written by Thomas Dekker. The Ramist concern for concrete and literal truth, as well as the systematic arrangement of arguments, provided a framework for popular genres like satire and social criticism. Thus, Ramism was not an esoteric philosophical doctrine but a lived and practiced methodology that shaped how people wrote, argued, and, crucially, organised their thoughts. It provided the intellectual scaffolding for the noun-oriented, taxonomical language that would come to characterise the period.

## LLM Semantics as Relational Trajectory

In stark contrast, the semantic architecture of an LLM operates on principles diametrically opposed to nominal fixity. Through the mechanism of self-attention, each token is defined not by an intrinsic essence but by its vectorial relationships to every other token within a given context window. The representation of a word such as “apple” is not a discrete entry in a mental lexicon but a high-dimensional coordinate whose proximity to “tree,” “Newton,” and “computer” shifts dynamically according to surrounding linguistic pressure. Meaning, in this framework, is generated continuously as a function of contextual probabilities; it is a trajectory rather than a location, a verb-like process rather than a noun-like substance. This operational reality aligns more closely with processual ontologies than with the substantival metaphysics that underpinned 17th-century

lexicography.

## The Bifurcation of Input and Interpretation

The interaction between human users and LLMs does not, however, effect a straightforward reversion to either historical pole. Instead, it produces a pragmatic bifurcation. At the level of input—the prompt—users instinctively resort to the reductive, noun-heavy syntax that characterised early modern legal and scientific discourse. Constructions such as “define the parameters,” “specify the constraints,” or “list the entities” serve to narrow the model’s infinite vectorial space, leveraging nominal rigidity as a computational affordance. Yet at the level of output interpretation, human validation reverts to an altogether more ancient faculty. The user does not assess the generated text by the fidelity of its nouns alone; rather, they evaluate its internal coherence, its narrative flow, and its accordance with an unstated, intersubjective understanding of the communicative situation. This evaluative act draws upon the deep evolutionary stratum of language as gesture and consensus, wherein meaning was indexed to shared attention and performative alignment rather than to lexical correspondence.

## Conclusion: The Detour of Fixity

It follows that the LLM does not function as a vehicle for historical return, but as a diagnostic instrument that exposes the contingency of nominal stabilisation. The early modern project of fixing English into a noun-oriented system was not the realisation of language’s essential nature, but a culturally specific detour—a useful fiction for governance, science, and commerce. By forcing users to oscillate between rigid prompting and fluid interpretation, the LLM reveals that meaning has always been, and remains, an emergent property of contextual consensus. The friction identified between 17th-century nominalism and LLM dynamism is thus not a contradiction to be resolved, but a productive tension that illuminates the deep temporality of language: a perpetual negotiation between the fixity required for social coordination and the fluidity demanded by genuine understanding. In this sense, we are not returning to the 17th century; we are, rather, awakening from it.